

THE MISCHIEF MONGERS

WHEN BLACK HATS TROLL OR MAKE FUN OF SOMEONE, THE WHOLE WORLD SITS UP AND TAKES NOTICE

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he world of technology will always be full of geniuses. Some use their talents for the greater good,

highlighting flaws for the sake of improvement, while others use their technical gifts for slightly more selfish reasons – personal amusement, bragging rights, spirit of adventure mixed and a bit of notoriety. They work in mysterious ways, are secretive and hidden from the world, and they get great kicks out of taking the mickey out of someone. Seduced by the dark side, their acts of mischief have brought them widespread fame.

HAPPY BIRTHDAY JOSHI

Legend has it that Prof Joshi taught at one of India's premier technical institutes, where colleagues and students made fun of his shy, reclusive nature. He turned a blind eye to all of that, but when not a single person on campus remembered or wish him on his birthday, as part of a prank, they didn't quite realise they were messing with the wrong guy. Prof Joshi vowed to teach everyone a lesson by making them all bow down to their knees – metaphorically speaking, obviously. By combining his unappreciated genius with his mad computer skills, Prof Joshi was ready

to announce himself to the rest of the world. The year was 1990 and he had just created India's first computer virus and it worked in a no-nonsense way.

While the above story may or may not be true, what certainly can't



You don't mess with the Prof

be denied is the outbreak of Happy Birthday Joshi virus in the early '90s. It spread mainly through floppy disks, infecting the boot sector of DOS-based computers at the time. The virus protected itself very well, flaring up on January 5 every time an infected machine was booted up by simply asking the user to "Type Happy Birthday Joshi". If they typed the message as per the instructions on screen, their computer would proceed to boot up normally. If they didn't, they were locked out of their machines as it hung after the message screen, forcing the frustrated user to reboot. You either did Joshi's bidding or remained locked out of your PC – there

was no other choice. If the virus christened by his name was any indication, one would think several times before messing with the Mysterious Mr Joshi.

"YOUR SECURITY IS CRAP"

In one of the most epic instances of hacking ever, Gary McKinnon – a British national and hacker extraordinaire – singlehandedly breached the cyber networks of multiple US government agencies. In a 13-month period in 2001-2002, McKinnon hacked into thousands of government computers belonging to NASA and the Pentagon, disrupting sensitive communications and causing damages worth hundreds of thousands of dollars. Under the pseudonym "Solo", McKinnon allegedly found incriminating evidence of the US government's suppression of UFO evidence and "free energy". Due to the damages and worldwide humiliation caused to them, the US government tried to extradite McKinnon from the UK for ten long years, but the hacker who



Extradition? Lol!